

TREMENDOUS TALONS

THERIZINOSAURUS

***Therizinosaurus* confused paleontologists for a long time.** When the bones of this plant-eating theropod were first discovered, they were thought to belong to a giant turtle. It was only after fossils of similar creatures were discovered that paleontologists pieced together the biology of this remarkable animal. *Therizinosaurus* was a tall dinosaur with massive claws on each arm and a sharp beak that it used to snap up plant matter. It is currently known as the largest of the maniraptorans, a group of feathered theropods that includes creatures such as *Velociraptor* and *Oviraptor*.

Paleontologists think that *Therizinosaurus* was feathered because of evidence of feathers found on the fossils of its close relatives.

Therizinosaurus had three curved claws, which it may have used as defensive weapons to deter predators.

AT A GLANCE

LENGTH 26–36 ft (8–11 m)
DIET Herbivore
LIVED 72–66 MYA
HABITAT Forests



STATS AND FACTS

24 IN
(60 CM)

CLAW LENGTH

UNIQUE FOOTPRINTS



Unlike most theropods, *Therizinosaurus* left behind four-toed footprints, which are distinctive and easily identifiable.

SLOW MOVING



Although strong, this dinosaur's short legs were not built for speed, and it probably could not outrun predators.

Therizinosaurus possessed the longest claws of any known modern or extinct animal. The claws were slightly curved, quite thin, and may have helped the theropod hook and pull branches down to its mouth.